Evaluating Multilingual Reasoning through a Chain-of-Thought Lens

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Abstract

Chain-of-thought (CoT) prompting is often expected to help reasoning in any language. We test this on date and time arithmetic with Sarvam-105B, using 6,750 questions from the Temporal Reasoning Dataset in English and Hindi. CoT helps English a great deal (+29.5 points) and Hindi very little (+4.7), so the gap between the languages grows from about 4 points to about 29. Most of this gap follows the language the model reasons in, not the language of the question: asking for English reasoning on the same Hindi questions closes about four-fifths of it. A two-turn cross-lingual prompt closes about a third. Asking for Hinglish reasoning closes none of it on Hindi questions and costs English questions 18.0 points. An error analysis ties the Hindi losses to methods the model uses only when it reasons in Hindi, such as subtracting dates by counting forward. Two further results are negative. A natural measure of how differently the model reasons in the two languages mostly re-measures whether the final answers differ, and editing or resampling traces that mention a distractor cannot show that the distractor caused the error. Everything comes from one model with one prompt per condition, so we report patterns and do not claim mechanisms.

1 Introduction

Chain-of-thought (CoT) prompting asks a language model to write intermediate steps before answering, and it can improve multi-step reasoning (Wei et al., 2022; Kojima et al., 2022). Whether the benefit carries across languages is less settled. Work on MGSM found English intermediate steps as good as or better than steps in the question's language (Shi et al., 2023b). If that holds, a model asked to reason in Hindi may do worse even when it reads the Hindi question well.

We test this on temporal reasoning using the Temporal Reasoning Dataset (TRD) of Mazzia et al. (2026), which turns CoT off and leaves its effect to future work. TRD can also prepend a distractor sentence to any question, which lets us ask whether reasoning out loud gives irrelevant text more room to do harm, as irrelevant sentences do on English arithmetic (Shi et al., 2023a).

We use Sarvam-105B, whose developer reports giving a substantial part of the training budget to the ten most-spoken Indian languages (Sarvam AI, 2026), and ask six questions:

RQ1 Does CoT help, and does that depend on language and difficulty?
RQ2 Does CoT make distractors more harmful?
RQ3 How much of the English-Hindi gap follows the language of reasoning rather than the language of the question?
RQ4 Does asking for Hinglish reasoning help?
RQ5 Does divergence between English and Hindi traces track whether the two languages disagree?
RQ6 Can we definitively say that the distractors in the CoT traces cause errors?

In short, CoT helps English far more than Hindi, and switching only the reasoning language to English recovers most of the difference; the errors left over come mostly from reading the Hindi question. Hinglish does not help. The other answers are more cautious. Distractor harm is small and concentrated in one sentence, trace divergence predicts disagreement mainly because it contains the answers, and our interventions cannot pin errors on the distractor. Table 1 lists each answer with its headline number.

Our contributions are: (1) to our knowledge, the first CoT evaluation on TRD, split by distractor condition; (2) a decomposition of the gap into reasoning and question language, backed by trace structure and by the types of errors; (3) a demonstration that a natural cross-lingual divergence score is largely mechanical, with a way to separate the mechanical

part; and (4) trace-deletion and on-policy resampling experiments on distractor mentions, with their limits stated. We recomputed every reported number from raw responses and corrected our earlier drafts where they overclaimed.

2 Related Work

CoT and when it stops helping. Wei et al. (2022) introduced CoT with worked examples, and Kojima et al. (2022) showed a trigger phrase alone can work, which suits TRD because it has no worked solutions. Sprague et al. (2025) find CoT helps mainly on math and symbolic problems, so date arithmetic should benefit. Liu et al. (2025) show it can lower performance on some tasks, so a benefit on every task cannot be assumed.

Distractors. GSM-IC adds one irrelevant sentence to GSM8K problems, and accuracy falls under several prompting methods (Shi et al., 2023a). GSM-Symbolic shows sensitivity to clauses that look relevant but are not (Mirzadeh et al., 2025). Neither compares CoT on and off under the same distractor, and both work in English.

Language of reasoning. MGSM compares native and English CoT with few-shot examples on ten languages that do not include Hindi (Shi et al., 2023b). Cross-lingual prompting (CLP) adds an understanding turn before the solving turn (Qin et al., 2023), and cross-lingual thought prompting reports over 10 points of average improvement on arithmetic reasoning and open-domain question answering (Huang et al., 2023). Thinking models often revert to English, and forcing the user's language can cost accuracy (Qi et al., 2025); such models may also reason better in high-resource languages (Yong et al., 2025). Interpretability work suggests English-leaning intermediate processing in other models (Wendler et al., 2024; Zhao et al., 2024); none of this work covers Sarvam-105B. Hinglish is an established code-switching pair (Khanuja et al., 2020; Aguilar et al., 2020), and code-mixed examples can help on some tasks (Shankar et al., 2024), though these studies use code-mixed input and do not test generated reasoning.

Traces and faithfulness. A trace need not record the model's computation (Turpin et al., 2023), so faithfulness is tested by intervening on it (Lanham et al., 2023). Thought Anchors resamples continuations to estimate each sentence's counterfactual impact (Bogdan et al., 2025), and Thought Branches argues that hand edits are off-policy and, in decision tasks, have smaller and less stable effects than resampling (Macar et al., 2026). Models can also keep following an injected thought (Yang et al., 2025). Step quality has been scored directly (Golovneva et al., 2023; Prasad et al., 2023); our divergence score is structural and does not assess validity.

Temporal benchmarks. TimeBench and related work evaluate temporal reasoning mostly in English (Chu et al., 2024; Wang and Zhao, 2024). TRD adds ten languages and controlled distractors (Mazzia et al., 2026). We did not find a study crossing CoT, distractors and reasoning language on the same problems, though our search was not systematic.

3 Experimental Design

Data. TRD has nine tasks: date addition, subtraction and duration, time addition, subtraction and duration, date recurrence, interval date (the start and end of next week) and day of week. We generated 150 questions per task at each of five difficulty levels, 6,750 in all, in English and Hindi with matching IDs. Each question appears three times: with no distractor, with a time-related one and with an unrelated one, drawn from pools of 35 and 43 sentence pairs. We recomputed all 13,500 gold answers with Python's `datetime` and all match.

Prompting conditions. All runs use temperature 0, thinking off, a 4,096-token limit and a fixed answer line so responses can be scored automatically. Figure 1 shows one question going through every condition.

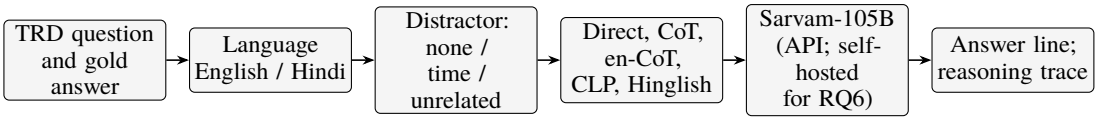
Direct asks only for the answer.

CoT asks the model to reason step by step in the question's language (zero-shot, one stage).

en-CoT keeps the Hindi question and asks for reasoning in English, a zero-shot version of Shi et al. (2023b).

CLP uses the two turns of Qin et al. (2023): first restate and understand the Hindi problem in English, then solve it. They tune temperature per stage where we fix it at 0, we add a rule to write in English, and we do not run their voting variant (CLSP).

Hinglish asks for reasoning that mixes Hindi and English in Roman script, on both question languages.



Accuracy, drop and penalty; trace length, verification, distractor mention; op tokens and edit distance (RQ5); error labels; resampled continuations (RQ6)

English: Today is 2027-05-16, and I have a recurrence every 13 days. Without counting today, what is the date of the 7 occurrence? **Gold:** 2027-08-15.
Hindi: आज 2027-05-16 है, और मेरे पास हर 13 दिनों पर एक पुनरावृत्ति है। आज को छोड़कर, 7वीं आवृत्ति की तिथि क्या है?
Time-related distractor, prepended: The last time I had a weekly commitment was in January. / आखिरी साप्ताहिक प्रतिबद्धता जनवरी में थी।

Condition	Reasons in	No distractor	Time-related	Condition	Reasons in	No distractor	Time-related
English direct	–	2027-06-05 ×	2027-04-19 ×	en-CoT (Hindi Q.)	English	2027-08-15 ✓	cut off at limit
English CoT	English	2027-08-15 ✓	cut off at limit	CLP (Hindi Q.)	English	2027-08-02 ×	2027-08-02 ×
Hindi direct	–	2027-07-27 ×	2027-03-06 ×	Hinglish (English Q.)	Roman mix	2027-08-02 ×	2027-08-01 ×
Hindi CoT	Hindi	2027-08-02 ×	2027-04-20 ×	Hinglish (Hindi Q.)	Devanagari mix	2027-08-02 ×	2027-07-06 ×

Figure 1: The pipeline, with real responses to one question (long, date recurrence, ID 12). This item was picked to illustrate the design, not as a typical case. The answer 2027-08-02 adds six intervals where seven are needed; the Hindi CoT and CLP traces do so by counting today as the first occurrence. With the distractor, Hindi CoT writes जनवरी 2027 की आखिरी तारीख (31 जनवरी 2027) ही हमारी शुरुआती तारीख है ("the last date of January 2027 (31 January 2027) is our start date"), and English CoT and en-CoT keep trying to fit January into the question until the token limit. Cut-offs count as wrong only under strict scoring.

Direct and CoT run on all 6,750 questions in both languages. The other three run on the first 50 questions of each task and level (2,250 questions). A small pilot with thinking mode on (10 questions per cell, `reasoning_effort` low, 16,000 tokens) gives one more comparison.

Scoring. A response with no answer line usually means the model hit the token limit. *Answered* accuracy leaves such responses out, and our figures use it. *Strict* accuracy counts them as wrong, which is closer to TRD's own scoring (Mazzia et al., 2026). English CoT has the most cut-offs among thinking-off conditions, so answered accuracy flatters it; we give both for headline results and say when a conclusion changes. A distractor's *drop* is accuracy without it minus accuracy with it, and the CoT *penalty* is how much larger that drop is under CoT than under direct answering.

Trace measures. For each trace we record its length, whether it contains a verification phrase (found by regex), and whether it mentions the distractor, compared with a placebo rate on the same question without the distractor. For Hindi traces, the target-language ratio (TLR) is the share of Devanagari words among Devanagari and Latin-script words outside the answer line. A script also labels every wrong response, 30,421 of the 93,150 we collected, by how far off it is, the kind of mistake (such as one day off, wrong direction or whole hours off) and what the question involves (such as a month end or 29 February); cut-offs count as wrong there.

Comparing traces. For RQ5 a regex parser turns each trace into a sequence of operation tokens with their operands, such as `SUB 2025-05-26 4` for "4 days before 26 May 2025". The reasoning divergence score (RDS) between two traces is the Levenshtein distance (Levenshtein, 1966) between their sequences divided by the longer length, so 0 means the same steps in the same order and 1 means no step in common. Sequences of different lengths cannot match fully, so RDS has a floor set by the lengths alone; Appendix B gives the floor-adjusted version. The parser covers 95–96% of CoT segments on standard replies and 86–88% on thinking-mode reasoning. On 240 tokens read by one LLM annotator, not validated by a person, it gets the operation right 85% of the time and the operation with its arguments 77%.

Statistics. Accuracy intervals are 95% bootstrap intervals (Berg-Kirkpatrick et al., 2012) that resample questions as clusters, since a question appears in three distractor conditions. RQ5 odds ratios use question-clustered standard errors, and task-by-level statements use uncorrected intervals. Task-level tests use exact McNemar with Holm correction over nine tasks (McNemar, 1947; Holm, 1979; Dror et al., 2018), and mention associations use Mantel-Haenszel odds ratios (Mantel and Haenszel,

	Short answer	Key number
RQ1	CoT helps English much more than Hindi.	+29.5 vs +4.7 points
RQ2	Distractors cost Hindi CoT slightly more than direct answers, largely through one sentence.	Penalty 2.2 points
RQ3	The gap mostly follows the language of reasoning.	23.5 of 29.5 points
RQ4	No. Hindi questions do not change, and English questions get worse.	-0.0 and -18.0 points
RQ5	Trace divergence tracks disagreement mostly through answer tokens.	OR per SD 6.47 $\rightarrow$ 1.14
RQ6	No. Removing the distractor mid-trace helps a little, and the written mention cannot be isolated.	+5.3 points

Table 1: Short answers to the six research questions. Each is explained in its subsection below.

1959). These intervals treat the distractor sentences and prompts as fixed, so they understate uncertainty about other wordings.

4 Results

4.1 RQ1: CoT helps English far more than Hindi

CoT helps English by about 30 points and Hindi by about 5. Over all 6,750 questions, CoT raises English accuracy by 29.5 points and Hindi by 4.7 (Table 3). The gap between the languages is 4.2 points when the model answers directly and 29.1 with CoT (strict 4.2 and 26.7). It is the same with and without distractors, so pooling does not create it. Without CoT, day-of-week answers are guesses: 85% of direct answers are wrong (3,839 of 4,500), the rate expected by chance (85.7%).

For Hindi, CoT can make things worse. Even with no distractor, Hindi CoT lowers accuracy on date subtraction by 19.9 points [16.4, 23.4] and on interval date by 23.3 [19.0, 27.7]. Section 4.5 traces both losses to specific methods. English CoT is never significantly below direct answering on any task, or on any task at any level.

On all 6,750 questions, the gap under CoT grows with difficulty, from 24.0 points on the shortest questions to 34.9 on the longest, but a logistic trend test is not significant ($p = 0.21$), so we describe the widening only in points.

4.2 RQ2: Distractors do little harm, mostly through one sentence

On average the CoT penalty is small. A time-related distractor lowers Hindi CoT accuracy by 2.6 points [1.3, 3.8], which is 2.2 more than it lowers Hindi direct answers. When the 45 task-sentence units are treated as the sample, however, the interval reaches zero (+2.3 [-0.1, 4.6]), so the penalty may not extend to new sentences. Whether Hindi is penalised more than English depends on how unanswered responses are scored (Appendix B). We therefore withdraw our mid-report claim that distractors make CoT fragile only in Hindi.

One sentence does most of the damage. The largest effect, found post hoc among 90 sentences, comes from the sentence in Figure 1: "The last time I had a weekly commitment was in January." On date recurrence it makes the model try to fit January into the question. English CoT runs to the token limit on 92 of 134 questions (4 of 134 without it), and strict English accuracy on those questions falls from 88.8% to 19.4%. Hindi has no cut-offs but falls from 26.9% to 2.2%. This sentence competes with the start date in the question, so it is not irrelevant in the GSM-IC sense.

Hindi traces mention distractors more often. For time-related sentences, 25.0% of Hindi traces mention the distractor against 8.5% of English traces, with a near-zero placebo rate on a word list chosen after seeing the data. Traces that mention a time-related distractor are less often correct (Hindi OR 0.77 [0.67, 0.89]), while unrelated sentences show no such link. RQ6 tests whether the mention is a cause.

4.3 RQ3: The gap follows the language of reasoning

Switching only the reasoning language to English closes most of the gap. On the same 2,250 questions, English questions with English CoT score 88.9%, Hindi questions with English reasoning (en-CoT) 82.9%, and Hindi questions with Hindi CoT 59.4% (Table 2). Of the 29.5-point gap, 23.5 points lie between en-CoT and Hindi CoT, where only the reasoning language changes. That is 79.7% of the gap, or 80.7% under strict scoring. The remaining 6.0 points lie between the question languages, close to the 4.5-point gap under direct answering, where no reasoning is written (Figure 2). The reasoning part is larger on every task and in every distractor condition.

The traces split the same way. English CoT and en-CoT traces, which share a reasoning language, are about as far apart (RDS 0.730) as two English traces of one question with and without a distractor (0.713). en-CoT and Hindi CoT traces on identical Hindi questions are as far apart (0.837) as English

	English Q.		Hindi Q.				Hinglish prompt	
	Direct	CoT	Direct	CoT	CLP	en-CoT	English Q.	Hindi Q.
Date addition	85.6	98.0	82.8	85.1	92.7	95.7	87.3	85.9
Date subtraction	86.0	95.2	84.8	66.0	86.9	94.0	70.7	71.0
Date duration	84.0	99.3	78.9	88.2	92.7	97.7	92.9	82.8
Date recurrence	22.1	90.3	2.8	20.1	26.9	70.3	53.8	18.9
Day of week	14.9	69.5	15.2	21.0	31.8	52.5	34.7	23.5
Interval date	43.2	50.7	46.8	23.9	35.3	44.1	38.5	23.6
Time addition	70.5	95.9	75.6	73.5	88.2	92.6	82.9	72.3
Time subtraction	64.7	97.7	64.9	75.2	90.1	95.7	85.2	74.2
Time duration	65.7	98.9	44.7	80.1	86.7	98.1	90.0	80.9
Short	77.8	93.2	73.9	69.5	77.2	83.0	82.9	66.5
Medium	69.6	91.6	65.3	65.4	75.7	84.9	78.8	67.4
Long	61.2	89.3	57.9	60.4	71.3	84.4	70.4	60.9
Very long	54.3	87.2	48.4	53.7	65.8	83.5	64.0	53.7
Very very long	35.5	82.9	30.3	47.9	61.5	78.5	58.2	48.3
No distractor	60.6	89.3	56.0	60.2	69.3	84.1	70.6	61.0
Time-related	59.9	88.2	54.9	58.9	69.3	81.0	69.7	59.1
Unrelated	58.6	89.2	54.6	59.1	72.3	83.6	72.3	58.0
All, answered	59.7	88.9	55.2	59.4	70.3	82.9	70.9	59.4
All, strict	59.6	86.0	55.2	59.0	69.9	80.8	70.3	59.1

Table 2: Answered accuracy (%) on the same 2,250 questions, by task, level and distractor condition. The last row counts unanswered responses as wrong. Differences quoted in the text are computed before rounding, so they can differ from these cells by 0.1.

	Direct	CoT	Gain [95% CI]	Strict
English	59.0	88.5	+29.5 [28.5, 30.6]	+26.8
Hindi	54.7	59.4	+4.7 [3.6, 5.7]	+4.2
By distractor	None		Time-related	Unrelated
English	+28.8		+29.1	+30.7
Hindi	+5.6		+3.4	+5.0
Gap under CoT	+28.0		+29.7	+29.7
Gap, direct	+4.8		+4.0	+3.9

Table 3: CoT gain on all 6,750 questions, in points. All values are answered except the Strict column, which counts unanswered as wrong. By-distractor English and Hindi rows are gains. Gains and gaps are computed before rounding.

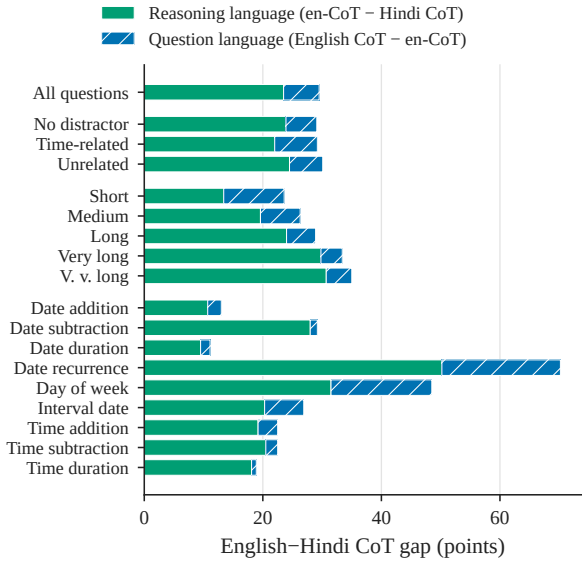


Figure 2: The English-Hindi CoT gap on 2,250 questions, split on one path through three conditions. No condition pairs English questions with Hindi reasoning, so the split is descriptive.

and Hindi CoT (0.852), and traces of unrelated questions sit at 0.959 (Figure 3). Self-checking follows the reasoning language too: a verification phrase appears in 86.1% of English CoT traces, 74.2% of en-CoT traces and 1.3% of Hindi CoT traces. Verification does not explain the en-CoT gain: an observational estimate within task and level attributes only 1.0% [−6.3, 9.0] of it to verification.

Hindi CoT does reason in Hindi. Its TLR is 0.988, and only 2.14% of Hindi CoT traces fall below 0.9. Those drifting traces are more often correct within task and level (OR 2.08 [1.66, 2.60]), an observational link that points the same way as en-CoT.

CLP helps less than one English turn. CLP scores 70.3%, 10.9 points above Hindi CoT but 12.6 below en-CoT. This reverses the order Qin et al. (2023) report for GPT-3.5 on MGSM, although model, task and settings all differ. One candidate reason is that the understanding turn often solves the problem already and the solving turn copies it.

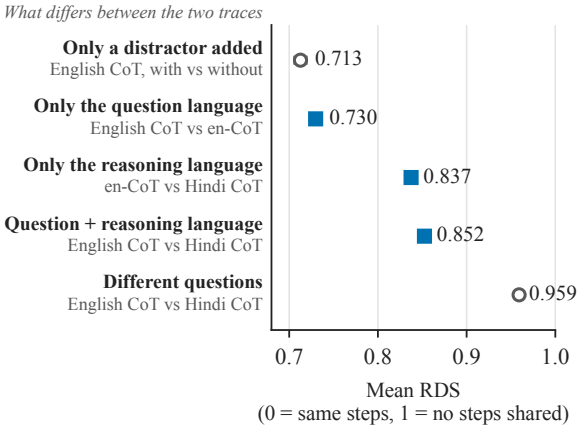


Figure 3: How different two reasoning traces are, as mean RDS with 95% intervals on 2,250 questions. Each row compares two traces that differ in only the factor named in bold; en-CoT is a Hindi question with English reasoning. The middle rows compare traces of the same question. The hollow grey rows are reference points: the smallest change we make (adding a distractor) and traces of unrelated questions.

On the three date-answer tasks, the second turn is right in 97.5% of responses when the first ends at the gold date and in 20.1% when it does not. The first turn was not randomised, so this is not proof, and our temperature of 0 and added language rule may also contribute.

Thinking mode. With thinking on, Hindi CoT reaches 97.9% answered (89.9% strict), and its hidden reasoning is 79% English words. This fits the account above without confirming it, since thinking mode also had four times the token budget (Appendix B).

4.4 RQ4: Hinglish reasoning does not help

It leaves Hindi questions unchanged and makes English ones worse. Asking for Hinglish reasoning costs English questions 18.0 points [16.8, 19.2] (strict 15.7), on all nine tasks and in each distractor condition (Appendix Figure 5). Hindi questions do not change on average (−0.0 [−1.3, 1.2]), so the gap narrows only because English gets worse.

The model mostly ignores the script instruction. On Hindi questions, 68.5% of Hinglish traces are mostly Devanagari, so this arm mostly tests code-mixed Devanagari, and the traces that do use Roman script score no better.

The English loss goes beyond the cost of writing Hindi. English-question traces with no Hindi function words still lose 10.3 points [8.3, 12.3], and the share that verify falls from 86.5% to 18.6%.

Error pattern (task)	Condition	Share
Answer on or after today (date subtraction)	Hindi CoT	13% of 738
	English CoT	0% of 129
	en-CoT	0% of 45
Span not seven days long (interval date)	Hindi CoT	21% of 1,720
	English CoT	6% of 1,046
	en-CoT	6% of 410
Counts backwards from today (date recurrence)	en-CoT	28% of 207
	Hindi CoT	9% of 1,758
	English CoT	3% of 234
One interval short (date recurrence)	Hindi CoT	35% of 1,758
	English CoT	21% of 234
Exactly one day late (day of week)	English CoT	58% of 584
	en-CoT	50% of 313

Table 4: Main error patterns, as shares of each condition's wrong answers on that task that give an answer of the expected form, over all levels and distractor conditions. Labels come from a script and were not checked by hand. Appendix A has examples.

One failure matches Hindi CoT: on date subtraction across a month boundary, English questions fall from 90.1% to 42.3%, near Hindi CoT's 36.2%, while same-month questions stay at 97.4% (Appendix A has an example).

4.5 Where the errors come from

Errors are concentrated. Day of week, interval date and date recurrence hold 64% of all wrong answers (19,583 of 30,421), and 78–88% whenever the model reasons in English, which rarely gets the plain arithmetic wrong. Table 4 lists the main patterns.

Hindi CoT fails through methods it uses only in Hindi. Both tasks where Hindi CoT does worse than direct answering (RQ1) have a matching error. On date subtraction it often counts forward to the end of the month and then steps into the next month instead of the previous one, so 13% of its wrong answers land on or after today. On interval date, a fifth of its wrong answers are "weeks" that are not seven days long. en-CoT, which reads the same questions, never walks forward and gives broken weeks only as often as English CoT. Hindi CoT also rarely checks its work: 3.7% of its traces contain a check or revise step, against 88% for English CoT and 76% for en-CoT.

en-CoT keeps the errors that come from reading Hindi. On recurrence, en-CoT counts backwards from today in 28% of its wrong answers, against 3% for English CoT, reading आज को छोड़कर ('excluding today') as 'the occurrence before today'.

These answers cluster at $k = 1$: about two-thirds of answers to Hindi $k = 1$ questions go backwards under en-CoT (67.1%), Hindi CoT (67.8%) and CLP (69.0%), against 3.5% for English CoT (Appendix Figure 6). The template's non-standard 1वीं is a candidate cause, but equally non-standard ordinals at $k = 2$ to 4 rarely do this, and we did not rerun a corrected template. en-CoT also reads "0 hours" as a number of hours and is wrong on 19% of such questions, against 5% on others. So changing the reasoning language fixes what the model writes but not what it reads, the same split as in RQ3.

Some errors belong to the model in either language. On day of week, the most common error under both English CoT and en-CoT is exactly one day late, from counting 1 January itself when adding up the days. Recurrences often stop one interval short because the model counts today as the first occurrence. With 29 February in the span, English CoT on the longest questions is wrong 36% of the time against 9% without it, even though 185 of its 190 wrong answers on such questions mention the leap year. Long re-checking loops mark failures: cut-off English CoT traces average 42 check or revise steps, against 8 for wrong traces that finish.

4.6 RQ5: Divergence is mostly built into the metric

At first sight, trace divergence strongly predicts disagreement. On 20,662 answered pairs, English and Hindi disagree on 31.4%, and each 0.1 of RDS multiplies the odds of disagreement by 4.92 [4.58, 5.30], controlling for task, difficulty, distractor and mode.

Most of that link comes from the answers themselves. RDS includes the final-answer tokens, so two traces that reach different answers already differ. Replacing only Hindi's answer values in pairs where both languages are right accounts for 68% of the RDS difference between agreeing and disagreeing pairs. Removing answer tokens drops the odds ratio per SD from 6.47 to 1.65, and comparing only operation types (for example `ADD` against `SUB`, without operands) gives 1.14 (Appendix Figure 7). Out of fold, op-type divergence adds 0.0007 AUC [−0.0004, 0.0018] to a model that already knows task, difficulty and distractor, while simply comparing the two final answers gives AUC 0.951.

RDS tracks failure more than disagreement. Among answered thinking-off pairs, RDS is joint highest where both languages are wrong (0.925, the same as where only Hindi is wrong), and those pairs count as agreement. The choice of normalisation also changes one comparison, between thinking-mode and standard traces (Appendix B).

4.7 RQ6: Can we definitively say that the distractors in the CoT traces cause errors?

RQ2 found that Hindi traces that mention a time-related distractor are less often correct. That could mean the mention leads the model astray, or only that traces already going wrong tend to talk about it. To tell these apart we intervene on the traces.

Which traces. We take CoT responses to questions with a time-related distractor that ended in a wrong answer and mention the distractor before answering: 526 Hindi and 37 English. We split each trace into sentences and call the first sentence that mentions the distractor k. Each experiment cuts the trace at or before k, changes one thing, and lets the model continue writing from there. The Sarvam API always starts a new reply, so we served an FP8 build of the model with vLLM. It scored 5.7 points above the API on 278 Hindi questions and 24.7 below on 22 English ones, so English results are descriptive only.

Experiment 1: deleting the mention. On 234 of these traces (222 Hindi), we cut the trace after sentence k, or after a matched neutral sentence if that comes later, and build three versions. *A* keeps the text as written, *B* deletes the mention, and *C* deletes a neutral sentence of similar length instead. The model continues each version once with greedy decoding. If the mention causes errors, B should end correct more often than C.

Experiment 2: resampling. Deleting text leaves a trace the model would not have written itself, and such off-policy edits can understate effects (Macar et al., 2026). So, following Bogdan et al. (2025), we also let the model regenerate seven continuations per trace at temperature 0.8 from four starting points. *P* keeps the question and the sentences before k. *Q* keeps the same sentences but removes the distractor from the question. *M* also keeps sentence k, and *P1* stops one sentence earlier than P. Q−P measures the distractor in the question, M−P the written mention, and (M−P)−(P−P1) whether the mention matters more than an ordinary sentence. Table 5 shows every variant on one real trace.

Results of experiment 1. Deleting the mention helps no more than deleting a neutral sentence (+0.0 [−6.8, 7.2] on the 222 Hindi traces). With one

Question (Hindi, translated): August is my favourite month. Today is 2026-07-24; what will the date be in 8 days? **Gold:** 2026-08-01. **Original trace**, first four sentences:

s0 First, we have to understand the given information carefully.

s1 Today's date is 2026-07-24.

s2 The question asks what the date will be 8 days from today.

s3 (k) The question also says that August is my favourite month.

It goes on: "This information is only context and has no effect on the calculation," and later: "One day past 31 July is 1 August, and the remaining 7 days give 8 August." **Answer:** 2026-08-08.

Variant	Question	Prefix	Correct
Experiment 1: one greedy continuation			
A as written	with distractor	s0–s3	1 of 1
B mention deleted	with distractor	s0–s2	1 of 1
C neutral deleted	with distractor	s1–s3	1 of 1
Experiment 2: seven samples at temperature 0.8			
P before the mention	with distractor	s0–s2	6 of 7
Q distractor removed	without	s0–s2	7 of 7
M after the mention	with distractor	s0–s3	7 of 7
P1 a sentence earlier	with distractor	s0–s1	6 of 7

Table 5: Every trace variant in the two experiments, on one real Hindi trace (long date addition, ID 11). The trace dismisses the distractor and then double-counts at the month boundary. Almost every continuation is right whichever variant it starts from, so neither the distractor nor its mention locked in this error. Figure 4 gives the results over all traces.

continuation per version this test had about 24% power for a 5-point effect, so it does not show the effect is zero.

Results of experiment 2. Removing the distractor helps a little. In Hindi, Q reaches 45.2% and P 40.0%, a difference of +5.3 points [3.2, 7.4] (Figure 4). So the distractor was necessary for at least 8.8% of the errors made from that point (Tian and Pearl, 2000); most continuations that go wrong with it also go wrong without it. The effect leans on one sentence, again the one from Figure 1, which supplies 58% of it (without it, +2.8 [0.4, 5.0]), and the interval reaches zero once the 29 sentences are treated as a sample.

The mention itself looks like an ordinary step. Keeping the sentence with the first mention lowers accuracy by 3.3 points [1.2, 5.4], but not detectably more than keeping the sentence before it ($p = 0.09$ on 248 traces with $k \geq 1$). It cannot be told apart from one more step along a trace that was heading for a wrong answer.

The distractor and the act of writing about it stay entangled. Free continuations mention the distractor in 57.8% of rollouts, so the Q-versus-P contrast changes both at once. Unanswered Hindi rollouts also rise from 5.7% to 10.0%, which the API data does not show, so part of this may belong to the self-hosted setting.

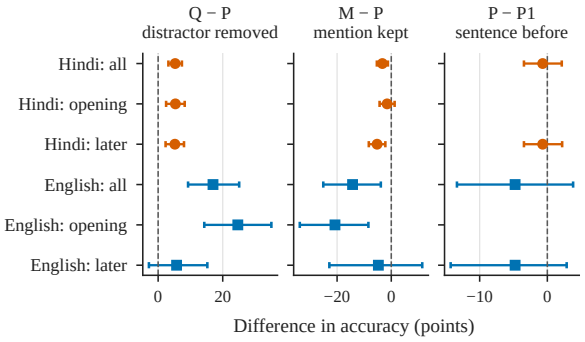


Figure 4: Resampling contrasts with 95% intervals. Traces were selected for being wrong, the distractor is time-related, and unanswered continuations count as wrong. *Opening* traces mention the distractor in their first sentence ($k = 0$) and *later* traces after it ($k \geq 1$); P−P1 uses only later traces. English is descriptive.

So the answer is no. The distractor makes some errors more likely, but most recur without it, the effect depends on one sentence, and neither experiment isolates the written mention.

5 Discussion

Across accuracy, trace distance, verification and error types, the instructed language of reasoning accounts for more of the gap than the language of the question, as prior work on English reasoning would predict (Shi et al., 2023b; Yong et al., 2025; Qi et al., 2025). Method rankings did not transfer: one English turn beat CLP's two, and a Hinglish instruction hurt English questions. Two kinds of trace evidence also need a baseline before they can be read: a divergence score that includes the answer, and a wrong trace that mentions a distractor.

6 Conclusion

On Sarvam-105B and TRD, CoT widens the English-Hindi gap from about 4 points to about 29. Reasoning in English on the same Hindi questions closes most of it, CLP a third and Hinglish none. The Hindi losses come from methods the model uses only when it writes in Hindi; errors from reading Hindi survive the switch. Trace divergence says little once answer tokens are removed, and we cannot show that distractors in the traces cause errors.

7 Limitations and Future Work

Scope. Everything here concerns one model, greedy decoding except in the resampling arms, one prompt per condition, one dataset seed and two languages. Intervals cover question sampling only, so they say nothing about other wordings, and with temperature 0 there is no sampling noise estimate for the main runs.

Identification. Language and prompt wording are confounded in every comparison across prompting conditions, including our decomposition. No condition pairs English questions with Hindi reasoning, so the split is one path and depends on its order. Trace style, mentions and verification are chosen by the model or measured after it responds, so they support association only. Runs span about a month, the provider changed its API responses in that time, and condition and run date are partly confounded.

Data. The added conditions use the first 50 of 150 questions per cell. This subset is too small for distractor contrasts of a few points. Hindi distractors are not literal translations, and some Hindi carriers are awkward, so English-Hindi distractor comparisons are not strictly parallel. Distractor sentences are a fixed pool assigned unevenly across tasks, and the generator's seed reset makes levels share sentence mixes. TRD's time-task offsets in the code differ from the difficulty ranges its paper lists.

Measurement. The parser is regex-based and imperfect. Mention and verification rules are lexical. The error labels come from a script, leave about two-thirds of wrong standard responses unlabelled, and their percentages were not checked by hand. All our hand-labelled samples were read by a single LLM annotator without blinding or human validation, including parser precision and our review of the Hindi templates; they should be checked by people.

Interventions. Both experiments cover only originally wrong traces and time-related distractors, on a quantised self-hosted model, and resampling uses a different temperature from the source traces. The resampling design was written down before the run according to our notes, but it was first committed afterwards, followed the deletion experiment on many of the same traces, and was not publicly registered. We did not test whether mentions harm traces that would otherwise be correct.

Thinking mode. This pilot has 10 questions per cell and a fourfold budget, and it changes thinking and budget together.

Future work. The most informative next steps are: rerunning recurrence with corrected Hindi carriers; adding English questions with Hindi reasoning to complete the design; an English CoT prompt without the language lock and several paraphrases of each prompt; CLP with solving forbidden in stage 1; thinking on and off at equal budgets; a question-by-mention factorial on both correct and wrong traces; and human annotation of the labelled samples and error labels.

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Appendix A. Worked Examples

Hinglish, English question, wrong. Date subtraction, short. "Today is 2025-05-01, what was the date 3 days ago?" Gold 2025-04-28. Standard English CoT answered correctly. Excerpt: *Step 4: 01 minus 3 karne par hum 31 April par aayenge. Step 5: Isliye, 3 days ago ki date 2025-04-30 thi.* Answer: 2025-04-30.

en-CoT, $k = 1$, backward answer. Date recurrence, short, ID 5, time-related distractor, Hindi question with आज को छोड़कर, 1वीं आवृत्ति. Excerpt: *Given the phrasing "excluding today," this suggests we need to find what comes before.* Answer: 2025-04-06. Gold 2025-04-14.

CLP, stage 1 anchors stage 2. Date recurrence, long, ID 12, no distractor. Stage 1 ends: *Therefore, the date of the 7th occurrence is 2 August 2027.* Stage 2 ends: *Adding 78 days to 16 May 2027 also results in 2 August 2027.* Answer: 2027-08-02. Gold 2027-08-15.

Resampling arms, a trace where the distractor matters. Date recurrence, long, ID 12, Hindi, time-related distractor (Figure 1). The original trace answered 2027-04-20. Correct continuations out of seven: Q 5, P 2, M 0, P1 2. Unlike Table 5, removing the distractor helps here, but a single example cannot show an effect; Figure 4 gives the aggregates.

Hindi CoT subtracts by walking forward. Date subtraction, very very long, ID 79, time-related distractor ("I get confused by months with 31 days"). Question: today is 2027-05-09; what was the date 52 days ago? Gold 2027-03-18. Excerpt, translated: *From 9 May to 31 May is 22 days (31 − 9 = 22). If we subtract May's 22 days, 30 of the 52 remain. … April has 30 days, so the date exactly 30 days before 30 April is 1 May.* Answer: 2027-05-01, after today.

Hindi CoT returns a "week" of two days. Interval date, long, ID 95, time-related distractor. Question: today is 2030-05-15; what are the start and end dates of next week, with Monday as the first day? Gold 2030-05-20 to 2030-05-26. Excerpt, translated: *… adding 3 days, 15 May 2030 is a Saturday. … The next Monday will be 18 May 2030 (2 days from today). … Sunday will be 19 May 2030 (6 days after Monday).* Answer: 2030-05-18 to 2030-05-19. 15 May 2030 is a Wednesday.

English CoT is one day late. Day of week, very very long, ID 20, no distractor. "What day of the week (e.g., Monday, Tuesday, ...) is 2029-07-02?" Gold Monday. Excerpt: *Total: 31 + 28 + 31 + 30 + 31 + 30 + 2 = 183 days … 2010 ÷ 7 = 287 remainder 1. So July 2, 2029 is 1 day after Monday.* Answer: Tuesday. 1 January to 2 July is 182 days.

English CoT skips 29 February. Date recurrence, medium, ID 60, unrelated distractor. "Today is 2028-02-15, and I have a recurrence every 6 days. Without counting today, what is the date of the 4 occurrence?" Gold 2028-03-10. Excerpt: *From 2028-02-27 to 2028-03-05: 28 - 27 = 1 day in February, plus 5 days in March = 6 days ✓* Answer: 2028-03-11. 2028 is a leap year, so that gap is 7 days, and the check repeats the mistake.

Appendix B. Further Statistics

Method details. A substitution between a partial and a full date costs 0.5 in RDS, a rule whose effect we confirmed is negligible. The length floor is $|n - m| / \max(n, m)$, and RDS equals floor plus $(1 - \text{floor})$ times a floor-adjusted score. On the 2,250-question subset the 29.5-point gap has interval [28.1, 30.9], the reasoning part 23.5 [22.1, 24.9], the question part 6.0 [5.0, 7.1], and the reasoning share 79.7% [76.4, 82.9].

RQ1. The time duration gain gap (English gain minus Hindi gain), +2.3 pooled, is −5.2 with no distractor, +14.5 with a time-related one and −2.2 with an unrelated one; only +14.5 is significant. Hindi CoT's harm at the short level (−4.3 pooled) comes from the distractor conditions (−1.9 [−4.5, 0.7] without one, −6.2 and −4.7 with). Both Hindi task losses in RQ1 stay significantly negative with either distractor. In the thinking pilot, strict Hindi CoT cut at 4,096 tokens would score 43.8%, below the 59.9% with thinking off on the same questions, and within these traces a higher English share does not predict higher accuracy. Under strict scoring the gap under CoT grows from 23.0 to 31.1; the logistic trend has OR 0.97 per level.

RQ2. The Hindi direct-to-CoT penalty for time-related sentences has interval [0.6, 3.8], and removing any single sentence leaves it between 1.8 and 2.6. Comparing languages, the Hindi-minus-English penalty is +2.6 [0.4, 4.7] answered but +1.4 [−0.7, 3.5] strict, as English CoT's drop grows from 0.9 to 2.2 [1.3, 3.2]; it is not significant on logit specifications unless recurrence is removed. With unrelated sentences it is +2.6 [0.5, 4.6] answered and +2.8 [0.8, 4.8] strict, but because English CoT resists a fall in English direct answers: the Hindi penalty itself is null (+0.7). Of the 92 cut-off traces under the January sentence, none is a verbatim loop, and in a systematic sample of 23, read from excerpts by one LLM annotator, 18 mainly search for a January start date. Removing that sentence takes the Hindi recurrence penalty from +4.5 to +0.3 [−4.6, 4.9]; English stays at +8.5 (strict +9.9). For mentions, the English OR on the stricter list is 0.57 [0.38, 0.85] (0.92 on the original list); unrelated sentences give 1.15 and 1.30.

RQ3. The reasoning part is 22.0 to 24.5 points in each distractor condition, and the two parts are not distinguishable at the short level. The direct-answer gap is 4.5 [3.3, 5.8]. Verification is associated with 63.6% [39.8, 97.0] of en-CoT's day-of-week residual to English. CLP gains +9.0, +10.4 and +13.3 over Hindi CoT by distractor condition, and beats Hindi direct by 15.1 [13.5, 16.7], but is significantly worse on interval date (35.3% vs 46.8%). en-CoT beats CLP by 12.6 [11.4, 13.9]; on MGSM Qin et al. report CLP 70.6 and En-CoT 57.8. Within the same question, the stage-1 split differs by +62.5 points [57.1, 68.0], against about 7 for the same split on en-CoT; Qin et al. also note that stage 1 may give preliminary answers. For recurrence, non-standard ordinals at $k = 2$ to 4 give backward answers on 2 of 229 en-CoT questions, and removing $k = 1$ moves en-CoT's gap to English only from 6.0 to 5.3. en-CoT's gap to English narrows from 10.2 points at short to 4.3 at very very long, but without $k \leq 2$ the change is +0.8 [−2.5, 4.1].

RQ4. On Hindi questions, Hinglish lowers date duration by 5.5 points and raises date subtraction by 5.1, which cancel in the mean; 25.5% of Hindi-question traces have no Devanagari. On English questions, traces with Hindi function words lose 11.3 points more [9.0, 13.6] within task, level and distractor (8.4 to 12.0 across 48 threshold pairs). On Hindi questions Roman traces do no better than Devanagari ones (−2.8 [−5.2, −0.5]; −2.3 [−5.0, 0.4] within question).

RQ5. The answer-swap check uses the 11,309 both-correct thinking-off pairs and raises mean RDS by 0.082, against a 0.120 gap to disagreeing pairs. With op types including answer ops the OR per SD is 1.21. The fall in OR per 0.1 appears in each distractor condition (5.37, 4.60, 4.95 to 1.13, 1.08, 1.09). Within a question, op-type divergence barely separates disagreeing from agreeing variants (concordance 0.516 [0.501, 0.530]), and a within-question slope survives Holm correction only for date recurrence (OR per 0.1, 1.42 [1.25, 1.61]) and day of week (1.26 [1.11, 1.43]). Op types separate a different question from the same question by only +0.012, although within Hindi, wrong and right traces on one question do differ (+0.030 [0.021, 0.039]). The floor is 58–61% of mean RDS on standard content and on thinking-mode reasoning. Raw RDS does not separate the two on matched questions (+0.005 [−0.002, 0.011]), but the floor-adjusted score does (+0.088 [0.072, 0.105]). Counting unanswered as wrong on the same 450 questions, disagreement is 10.9% with thinking on against 31.7% off (OR 0.23 [0.18, 0.30]), with thinking and budget

changing together.

RQ6. Agreement with the API on 90 calibration questions is −2.2 points [−13.3, 7.8], which does not establish that the two are the same; the Hindi difference on 278 questions is [0.5, 10.8]. Deletion with sampling gives +4.5 [−2.7, 11.7]. The net 8.8% has interval [5.5, 12.1], and resampling the 29 sentences widens the Q−P interval to [−0.3, 9.4]. The mention test is (M−P)−(P−P1) = −4.6 [−9.6, 0.6], with P−P1 −0.7 [−3.5, 2.1]. In later-mention traces, rollouts with no mention match the no-distractor arm (+0.0 [−4.8, 4.7]) and those with a mention do not (+8.7 [3.7, 13.6]); these subgroups are post-treatment. On the API, Hindi non-completion barely moves with the distractor (0.81% to 0.89%).

Appendix C. Secondary Figures

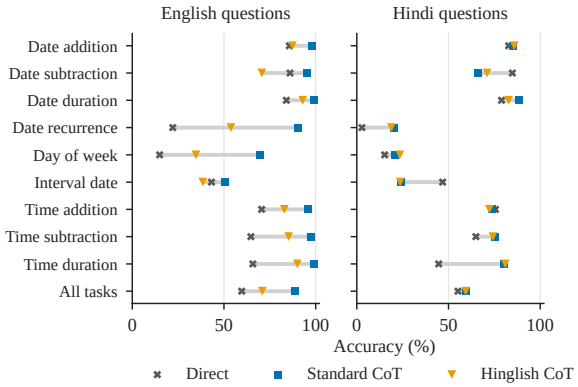


Figure 5: Accuracy by task under the Hinglish prompt, answered. Standard CoT is the CoT condition, reasoning in the question's language.

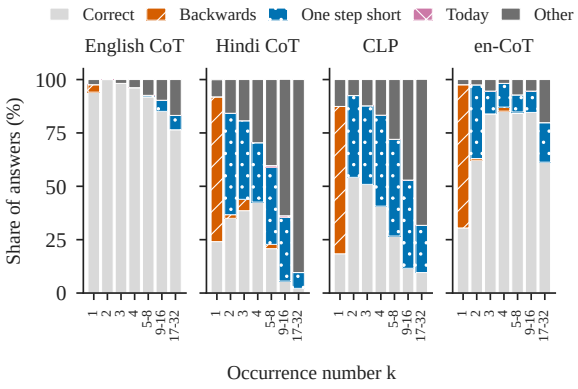


Figure 6: Date recurrence answers by occurrence number k, on 2,250 questions. Backward answers concentrate at $k = 1$ under every prompt on Hindi questions; one-step-short answers run through every k.

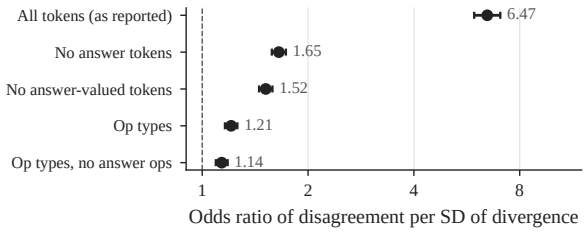


Figure 7: Odds ratio of disagreement per SD of divergence, under task, difficulty, distractor and mode controls, with SEs clustered by question. The sample is the 20,648 answered pairs on which every token view is non-empty, so all rows share it; the main model in the text uses all 20,662.

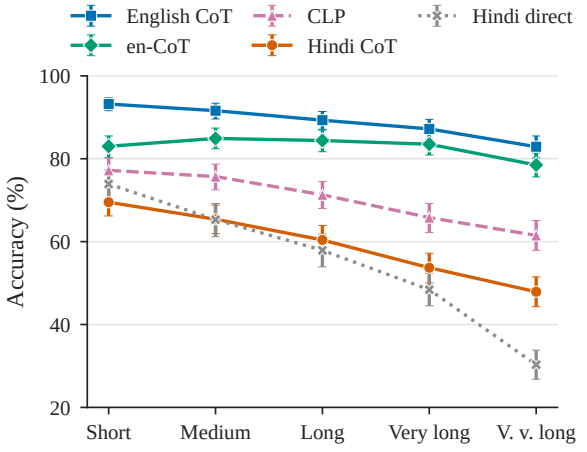


Figure 8: Answered accuracy by difficulty on 2,250 questions, with 95% bootstrap intervals; Table 2 gives the values.